

Module 2: ISO 9001:2015 Structure and Requirements

Introduction to Quality Management and ISO 9001 | QMS-9001

1. The High-Level Structure (Annex SL)

ISO 9001:2015 follows the High-Level Structure (HLS) defined in Annex SL of the ISO Directives. This structure provides a common framework for all ISO management system standards, making it easier to integrate multiple standards (e.g., ISO 14001, ISO 45001) within a single organisation.

The 10 clauses of ISO 9001:2015 are:

- Clause 1: Scope
- Clause 2: Normative References
- Clause 3: Terms and Definitions
- Clause 4: Context of the Organisation
- Clause 5: Leadership
- Clause 6: Planning
- Clause 7: Support
- Clause 8: Operation
- Clause 9: Performance Evaluation
- Clause 10: Improvement

2. Clause 4 — Context of the Organisation

Organisations must identify internal and external issues relevant to their purpose and strategic direction. This includes understanding the needs and expectations of interested parties (stakeholders). The scope of the QMS must be defined and documented.

3. Clause 5 — Leadership

Top management must demonstrate leadership and commitment by taking accountability for the effectiveness of the QMS, ensuring that the quality policy and objectives are established, and promoting a culture of continual improvement.

4. Clause 6 — Planning

ISO 9001:2015 introduces risk-based thinking as a core concept. Organisations must identify risks and opportunities that could affect their QMS and plan actions to address them. Quality objectives must be measurable and monitored.

5. Clause 8 — Operation

This clause covers the operational planning and control needed to meet requirements for products and services. It includes design and development, control of externally provided processes, production and service provision, and control of nonconforming outputs.

6. Clause 9 — Performance Evaluation

Organisations must monitor, measure, analyse and evaluate their QMS performance. This includes customer satisfaction monitoring, internal audits, and management reviews.

7. Clause 10 — Improvement

The organisation must continually improve the suitability, adequacy and effectiveness of the QMS. Nonconformities must be corrected and their causes eliminated through corrective action. The organisation shall seek opportunities for improvement.

Key Learning Points

- ISO 9001:2015 uses a process approach combined with PDCA and risk-based thinking.
- The standard does not prescribe how organisations should operate — it sets requirements that outcomes must meet.
- Documented information replaces the concept of 'documents' and 'records' from earlier versions.
- Certification is voluntary but widely required in supply chains and public sector procurement.